ELI — Using Ollama (Start to Finish)

ELI v2.5.16

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Contents

Using Ollama with ELI — a start-to-finish guide (no tech knowledge needed) **1**
- What is Ollama (in one sentence)? . . . 1
- Step 1 — Install Ollama (once) . . . 2
- Step 2 — Get a model (once) . . . 2
- Step 3 — Tell ELI to use Ollama . . . 2
- Step 4 — Change it whenever you like . . . 3
- If something doesn't work . . . 3
- The one-minute version . . . 3

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> **Updated for v2.4.84.** The Ollama model picker in Settings / startup works on AppImage and portable builds (Qt compat shim exports `QDialogButtonBox`).

This guide is for anyone who wants ELI to use an **Ollama** model. You don't need to understand any of the words below — just follow the steps for your computer.

The good news: as of **v2.1.29**, if Ollama is installed on your machine, **ELI starts it for you automatically**. Most people don't have to do anything except install Ollama once and pick a model. The steps below cover installing it and what to do if anything doesn't work.

What is Ollama (in one sentence)?

Ollama is a free program that runs AI "brains" (models) on your own computer. ELI can borrow those brains instead of using its own. Everything stays on your machine.

You do NOT need Ollama to use ELI — ELI comes with its own brain. Ollama is only if you *want* to use models you've set up in Ollama.

Step 1 — Install Ollama (once)

Pick your computer:

Windows

1. Go to **https://ollama.com/download** in your web browser.
2. Click **Download for Windows**, then run the file you downloaded.
3. Click through the installer (Next → Next → Finish). That's it — Ollama now starts automatically every time your computer turns on. You'll see a small llama icon near your clock.

macOS (Apple computers)

1. Go to **https://ollama.com/download**.
2. Click **Download for macOS**, open the downloaded file, and drag **Ollama** into your Applications folder.
3. Open **Ollama** once from Applications. It runs quietly in the menu bar (top of your screen) from now on.

Linux

1. Open a **Terminal**.
2. Copy-paste this one line and press Enter:

   ```
   curl -fsSL https://ollama.com/install.sh | sh
   ```

3. That installs Ollama and sets it to run in the background.

Step 2 — Get a model (once)

A model is the actual "brain". You download one with a single command. Open a **Terminal** (macOS/Linux) or **Command Prompt / PowerShell** (Windows) and type:

```
ollama pull llama3.2
```

Wait for it to finish (it downloads a few gigabytes the first time). You can pull others later — `ollama pull qwen2.5`, `ollama pull mistral`, and so on. Browse them at **https://ollama.com/library**.

> Tip: a smaller model like `llama3.2` or `qwen2.5:3b` is a good first choice — it loads faster and runs on modest computers.

Step 3 — Tell ELI to use Ollama

1. Start ELI. On the **first screen** ("Choose which model to load"), find the **Provider** dropdown near the top.
2. Choose **Ollama**.
3. In **Ollama model**, click **Refresh Ollama models** and pick the one you pulled in Step 2 (for example `llama3.2`).
4. Click **OK**.

That's it — ELI now thinks using your Ollama model.

You can also just **ask ELI** later: say or type *"switch to Ollama"* or *"use the llama3.2 model"*.

Step 4 — Change it whenever you like

- **In the app: Settings → Model → Backend = Ollama**, then **Refresh Ollama Models** and pick one.
- **By talking to ELI:** *"use the mistral model"*, *"what Ollama models do I have"*.
- **Back to ELI's own brain:** set **Backend** to **Bundled** or **Custom GGUF**.

If something doesn't work

ELI starts Ollama only when you choose it: pick **Ollama** as the backend in the start-up dialog or in **Settings → Model**, or pick an Ollama model in the toolbar menu. Then, if the `ollama` program is installed but stopped, ELI starts it for you. With a GGUF model chosen ELI never starts or uses Ollama, and listing Ollama's models never starts it. If you chose Ollama and still see **"Ollama unreachable"**:

1. Is Ollama installed? Open a Terminal / Command Prompt and type `ollama list`. If it says *command not found*, go back to **Step 1**.

2. Is a model downloaded? If `ollama list` is empty, do **Step 2** (`ollama pull llama3.2`).

3. Start it by hand (rarely needed): - **Windows / macOS:** just open the **Ollama** app (Start menu / Applications). - **Linux:** type `systemctl --user start ollama` — or `ollama serve` and leave that window open.

4. Ollama on a *different* computer (advanced): You can point ELI at Ollama running on another machine on your home network. In **Ollama host**, type that machine's address (e.g. `192.168.1.20` — you don't need `http://` or a port, ELI fills those in). On that other machine, start Ollama with `OLLAMA_HOST=0.0.0.0:11434 ollama serve` and allow port `11434` through its firewall. ELI treats a machine you set here as trusted, so the Net toggle can stay **off**.

5. Turn off auto-start (if you prefer): Even with Ollama chosen, ELI starting it for you can be disabled by setting the environment variable `ELI_OLLAMA_AUTOSTART=0`; you then start Ollama yourself.

The one-minute version

1. Install Ollama from **https://ollama.com/download** (once).
2. `ollama pull llama3.2` (once).
3. In ELI's first screen: **Provider → Ollama → Refresh → pick your model → OK**.
4. ELI starts Ollama for you from then on. Done.